If it were not for his unwavering determination to transform the group, the Tatas could have taken a path like that of many other industrial houses and become an outlier in the Indian economic landscape.

A Benchmark for the World

The performance of Tata companies under Ratan serves as an example for other Indian organizations to follow, especially the way he navigated them through the period of transition of the Indian economy. It also has lessons for business houses across the globe.

Kissinger said that Ratan would qualify to be categorized amongst the top 2 per cent of the world's businessmen. He added: 'I can't think of any other business leader that had the same impact on the country and is so forward thinking,' he says.

What makes Ratan's achievements remarkable is that when he came to the helm, industrial houses in India were convulsed by the 1991 economic liberalization. The difficulties were compounded by legacy issues, as he was saddled with companies that were set in a conservative style of functioning in the protective environment of the Licence Raj. They were ill-suited to survive in a competitive environment.

But during his tenure, the Tata Group grew in strength and retained its preeminent position as the largest industrial house in the country—a rare achievement that has little or no parallel elsewhere.

Even in the Mecca of capitalism, the US, in modern times there is no example of any one company or group retaining its top position for decades. In the *Fortune* 100 list of the US companies (ranked by revenue), General Motors, which was number one in 1991, slipped to the fifth position in 2012. Only twenty-eight companies that were in the list in 1991 (in the first 100) even found a place in the 2012 rankings. Three companies which were in the first 10 in 1991 did not even make it to the top 100 list in 2012.

In comparison, not only did Ratan navigate the Tata Group through turbulent times, he also managed to beat the competition from newer groups. In contrast, other traditional and old industrial houses were unable to retain their position in the BSE 100 index. While in 1992, there were eighteen major business groups ranked according to market cap, by the time Ratan stepped down, there were only six—Tata, Aditya Birla, Bajaj, Hinduja, Mahindra and Reliance. The other old and venerated industrial